02

PART 2 OF 9

The Patriarchs

GEN 12–50

From Ur of the Chaldeans to Goshen in Egypt: the journey of a family that carried a promise.



PART 2 · GEN 12–50

The Fathers of Faith on the Road

From the twelfth chapter of Genesis, the story changes scale. Instead of the history of all humanity, we read about one family that sets out from southern Mesopotamia and crosses the Fertile Crescent as far as the Nile delta. Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, and Joseph do not live in a misty land of legends, but beside real wells, on hills, at river fords, and along caravan routes. This part of the atlas shows that the story of the patriarchs is also the story of a landscape, where shepherds searched for water, pasture, and safety for their flocks.

Imagine a world where the boundary is not walls but the distance to the nearest spring. The patriarchs moved with their tents and flocks along the strip of land between desert and sea, avoiding the mighty city-states. They traveled along the watershed of the hills of Judea and Samaria, went down to the Negev in the dry season, and in times of famine looked for grain along the Nile. Such a life required trust, skill in negotiating with neighbors, and a memory of the places where water had once been found.

In this part you will visit twelve places and follow four maps. You will see Ur, Haran, and Shechem, the oak at Mamre, the area around the Dead Sea, Bethel, the ford of the Jabbok, Dothan, and Egypt. Remember that the locations of some places are traditional, and the reconstructions are artistic interpretations based on archaeological knowledge of the Bronze Age. Distances are given as approximations. This will help you understand why the promise given to one family was tied to this very land and this very road.

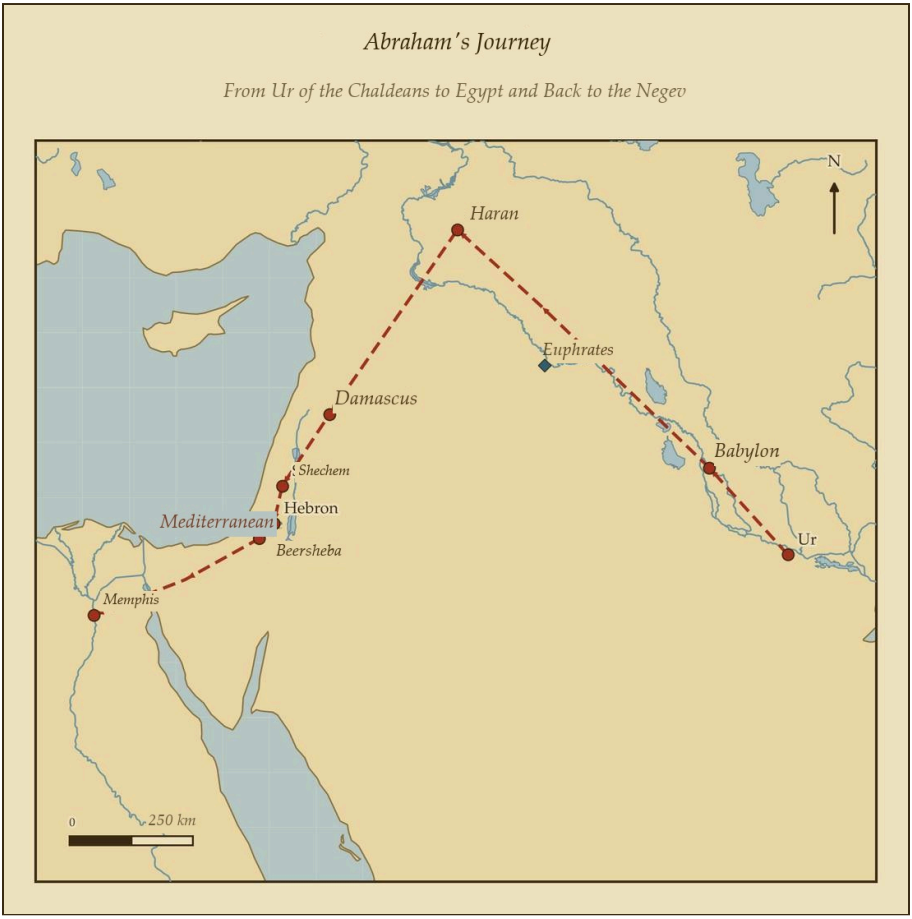
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HOW TO USE THIS ATLAS

The maps show routes and the locations of places; the illustrations are artistic reconstructions based on archaeological knowledge, not photographs. Distances and dimensions are approximate.

MAP 2.1



The first route shows the road from southern Mesopotamia along the Euphrates through Haran and Damascus to Shechem. The second leads from Canaan to Egypt, where Abram seeks grain during a famine.

The map compares the scale of two stages of Abraham's life. The first is a journey of over 1,500 km around the Fertile Crescent, which arcs around the Syrian desert. The second is a shorter trip of about 500 km through the Negev and Sinai to the delta of the

Nile. In both cases the road runs from spring to spring. All routes are approximate, because the Bible gives no details of the way, and the identification of some places is traditional.

MAP 2.2

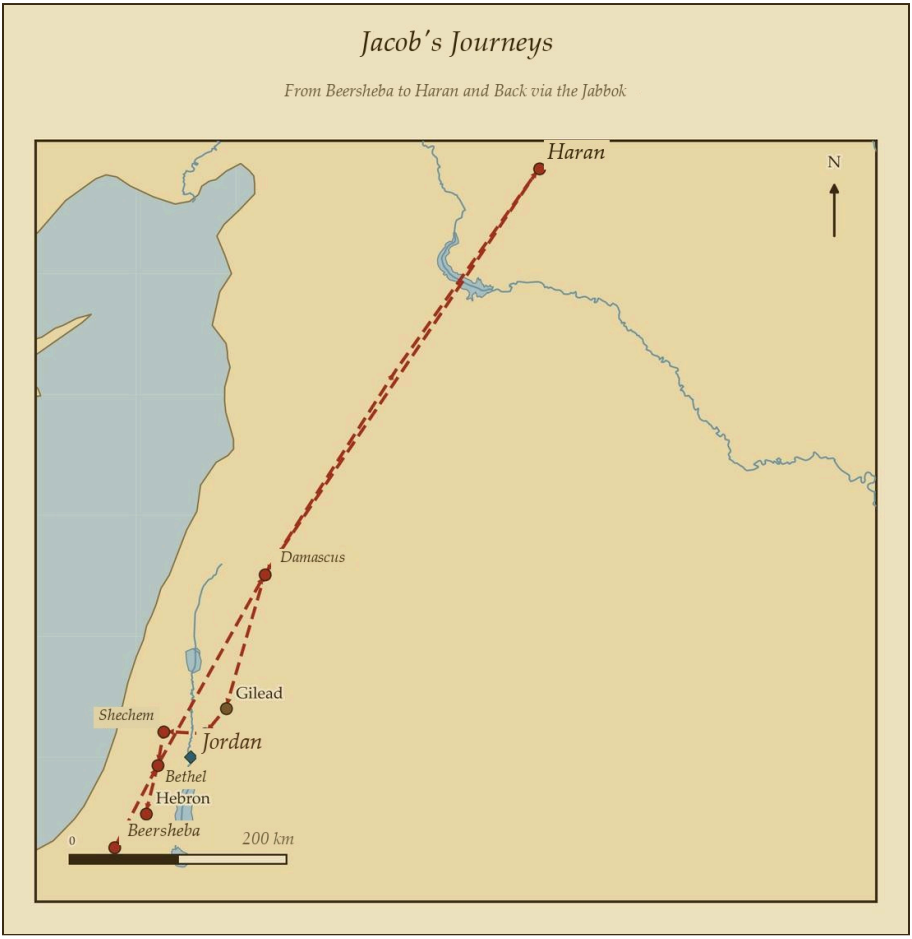


The line shows the main road along the mountain ridge from Shechem in the north to Beersheba in the south. The Dead Sea lies to the east, in a deep rift valley.

This map shows that all the important places in the lives of Abraham and Isaac lie within a stretch of less than 120 km. The family kept to the higher parts of the hills, where rainfall was greater and the road was safe. To the east the land dropped steeply into the

Jordan Rift, and to the south the Negev began. It is easy to see how small this territory is compared with the vast distances the patriarchs had earlier traveled in Mesopotamia.

MAP 2.3

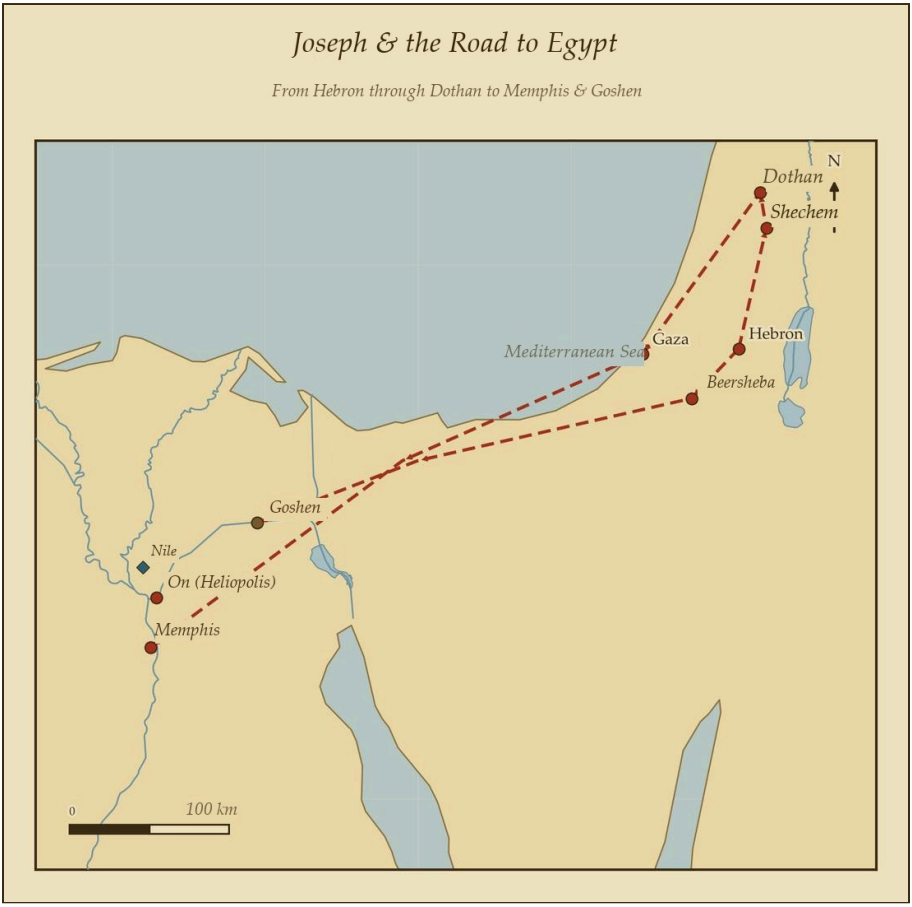


The first line shows Jacob's flight north from Esau. The second shows his return years later through Gilead, the ford of the Jabbok, and Shechem as far as Hebron.

Jacob travels about 1,500 km in each direction. The map shows that the return skirts the Jordan on the east, through Gilead, rather than taking the shortest route across the desert. This brings Jacob into Canaan from the side of the Jabbok, where the night trial awaits

him. Bethel, Shechem, and Hebron mark the successive stages of the return to his father's house. The routes are only indicative, since the biblical text mentions just some of the stopping places.

MAP 2.4



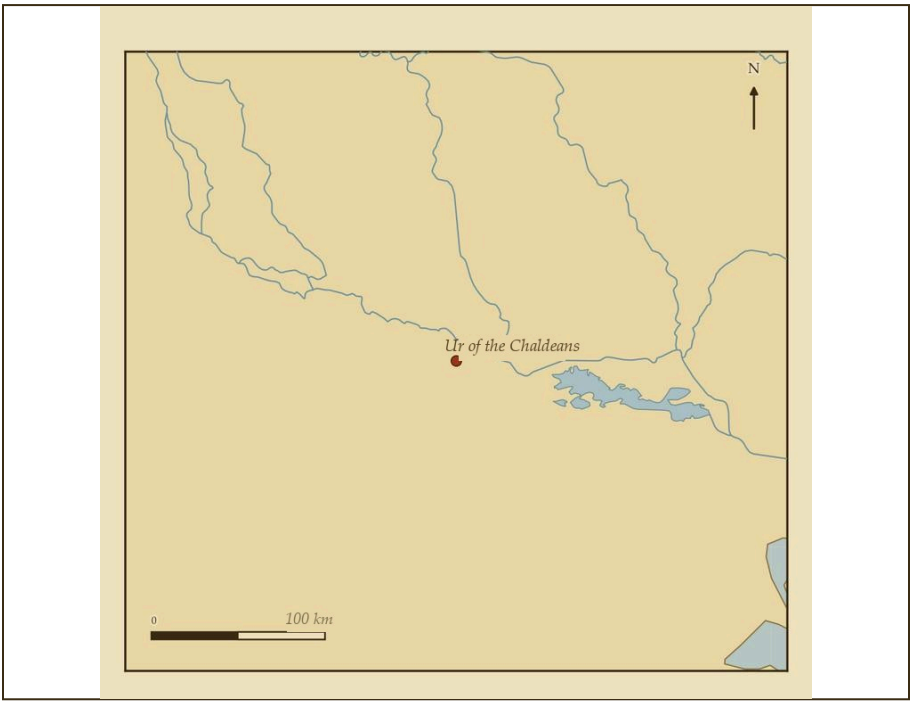
The first route shows Joseph's journey from his father's house through Dothan along the coastal road to Memphis. The second takes Jacob from Hebron through Beersheba to the land of Goshen.

The map shows that Egypt lay relatively close to Canaan: from Hebron to Goshen it is about 400 km, roughly two weeks on foot. The route along the coast and across northern Sinai was well known to merchants, and Egypt also drew Canaanites in times of famine. This allowed Jacob's family to find refuge quickly and keep its bond with the land of their fathers. The routes are approximate.

01 Ur of the Chaldeans

GEN 11:27–12:3

From here Abram sets out at the call of a voice that promises him a land and a great nation.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a city of sun-dried and baked brick, surrounded by grain fields and date palms. Above the rooftops rises a multi-tiered temple tower called a ziggurat, visible from afar on the flat plain. Narrow streets wind between houses with courtyards, and canals link the districts to the river. Reed and wooden boats loaded with goods are moored at the quay. At Ur, archaeologists have uncovered rich tombs and buildings from the early third and second millennia before Christ.

Terah's family comes from Ur of the Chaldeans. According to Genesis, Terah leads his household out, including his son Abram, his grandson Lot, and his daughter-in-law Sarai, and heads toward Canaan. The journey stops at Haran, however, where the family settles. Only there does Abram hear the call to leave his native land and his father's house, and in return receives the promise of descendants, blessing, and a land. The text does not describe the reasons for the departure, but it shows that the decision meant a break with his entire social background.

Ur lay in southern Mesopotamia, near the old bed of the Euphrates, not far from the ancient shore of the Persian Gulf. The area was flat, irrigated by canals, and very fertile, so the city grew rich on trade and farming. The road northwest ran along the Euphrates, through Babylonia and on toward Syria. This route was over a thousand kilometers long and gave constant access to water, but it also meant passing the settlements of rulers who collected tolls from caravans. The family's journey was therefore an undertaking that required careful planning.

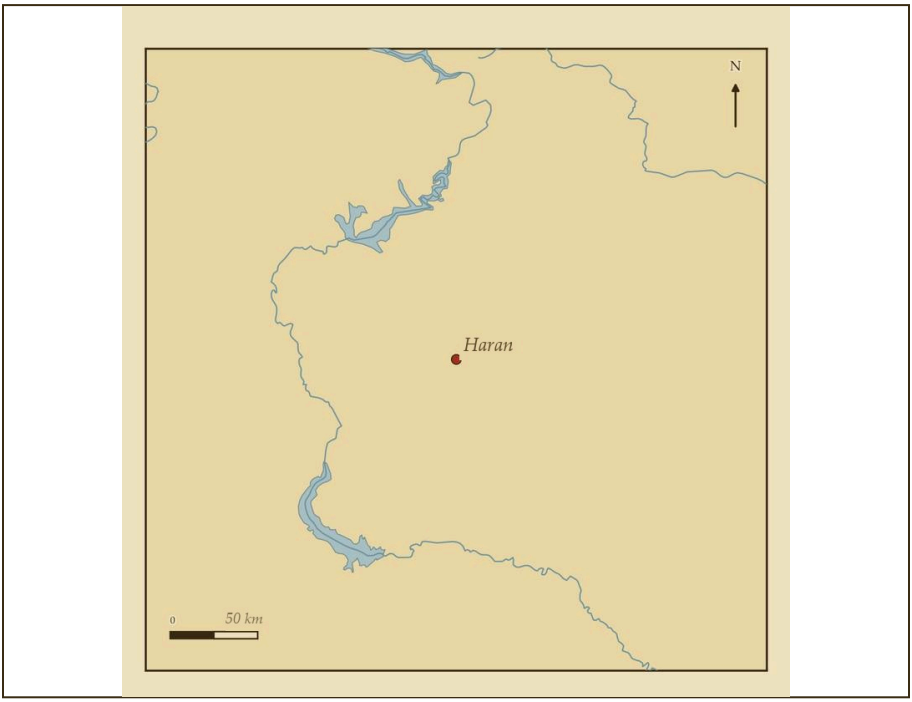
FACTS

Distance Ur–Haran along the Euphrates: about 1,000–1,200 km.

02 Haran

GEN 11:31–12:5

A city in northern Mesopotamia, where Abram stays until his father's death and from which he moves on.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a fortified town on a gently raised plain, with walls of brick and stone and a cluster of houses around a temple. Fields and pastures stretch all around, and shepherds with sheep gather at the wells. Paths converge at the city gate, where donkey caravans unload their goods. In winter a cold wind blows here, and in summer the heat is severe. Important trade routes passed through the city.

Haran is a resting place that becomes a starting point. When Terah dies, Abram takes his wife Sarai, his nephew Lot, all the possessions they had gathered, and the people they had acquired in Haran, and heads south. The biblical tradition calls the surrounding region Aram Naharaim, the land by the rivers. Abraham's servant later seeks a wife for Isaac here, and Jacob flees here from the anger of his brother Esau. For generations, then, the family keeps ties with this land and remembers its roots.

Haran lay on the Balikh River, a tributary of the Euphrates, in what is now northern Syria and southern Turkey. The climate is semi-arid, yet the gentle hills and plains offer good pasture for sheep and goats. The city stood at the crossroads of routes leading to Anatolia, Syria, and Mesopotamia, which made it an important trading center. From here the road to Canaan ran through Aleppo and Damascus, about 800–900 km long. For slow-moving flocks, that meant a journey of several weeks.

Most scholars identify Haran with the modern city of Harran in Turkey.

FACTS

Haran to Shechem: about 700–800 km in a straight line, and more by road.

03 Shechem

GEN 12:6–7; 33:18–20; 34

Abram's first stop in Canaan, between Mount Gerizim and Mount Ebal.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a narrow valley with two steep mountains on either side. An olive grove grows at their feet, and on a hillock stands a walled town with a gate tower. Beside the road, shepherds water their flocks at a well. In the distance, rocky slopes with sparse vegetation can be seen on the summits. In spring the valley is green, and in summer dry and golden. The patriarch's tents stand off to one side, outside the town walls.

After arriving in Canaan, Abram passes through the land as far as a place called Shechem, near the great tree of Moreh. Canaanites live there at that time. At this place God renews the promise of the land to his offspring, and the patriarch builds an altar. Many years later Jacob, returning from Haran, pitches his camp before the city and buys a plot of land from the sons of Hamor. Chapter 34 tells of a conflict that erupts after the violation of Dinah and leads to violence by Jacob's sons. Shechem thus remains a place of both promise and painful memory.

Shechem lies in a valley between two mountains, Gerizim and Ebal, which rise several hundred meters above it. The main north–south road runs through this spot along the ridge of the hills of Ephraim, easier and safer than the lowland routes where the city-states held sway. Abundant springs provided water, and the slopes favored the growing of olives and grain. It was therefore a natural place for shepherds to stop. From Shechem to Bethel it is about 30 km to the south, a day or two of travel with flocks.

The name Shechem is linked with present-day Tell Balata near Nablus.

FACTS

Height of the mountains: Gerizim about 881 m above sea level, Ebal about 940 m.

04 Mamre near Hebron

GEN 13:18; 18:1–15

Under a great tree, Abraham welcomes three mysterious guests.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

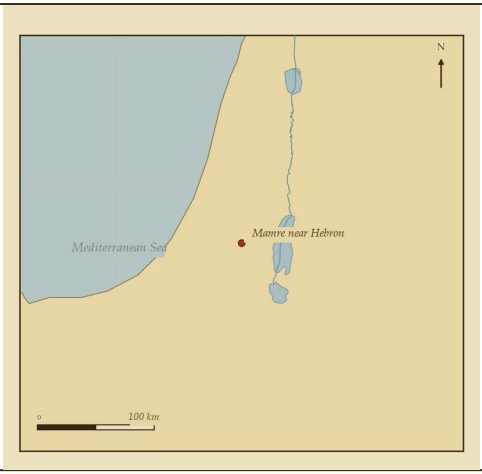
The artistic reconstruction depicts a hot noon. An old, spreading oak casts deep shade over a tent of black goat hair. An elderly man sits in front of it, and in the distance three figures approach. Sheep and goats graze all around, and vineyards and olive trees grow on the hillside. The air shimmers with heat, the ground is dry, and the sky is faded. All of it unfolds in the stillness of a pastoral afternoon.

After parting from Lot, Abram moves his tents to the grove of Mamre near Hebron and builds an altar there. In the heat of noon, as he sits at the entrance of his tent, he sees three men. He runs to meet them, bows low, has water brought to wash their feet, and asks Sarah to bake bread. The meal consists of milk, curds, and veal. The guests announce that in a year Sarah will bear a son. Sarah, hearing this at the tent, laughs, and the name Isaac will recall that laughter. Christian tradition sees in the scene hospitality as a virtue.

Hebron lies at an elevation of about 900 m above sea level, on the watershed of the hills of Judea, where rainfall is higher than in the desert and the soils suit the growing of grapes and olives. Winters can be cool, and in summer the altitude eases the heat. The ridge road linking Beersheba with Jerusalem passes through the area, about 70 km long. Ancient trees gave shade, and wells and pastures made it possible to sustain large flocks. Mamre was therefore an ideal place for the family's permanent camp, safely far from the great cities.

FACTS

Hebron lies about 900 m above sea level, about 30 km south of Jerusalem.


N
Mediterranean Sea
Mamre near Hebron
0
100 km

05 Sodom and Gomorrah by the Dead Sea

GEN 13:10–13; 18:16–19:29

The Jordan Valley that Lot chose ends in the catastrophe of the cities of the plain.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows the valley at dawn, seen from a high ridge. Below, the smooth surface of a salt sea gleams, ringed by white salt deposits and bare cliffs. A streak of dark smoke rises from the plain. Closer by is a stony path, and on it a lone figure looks down, back turned. The air is thick with mist, and the light of the rising sun reddens the rocks on the far side.

2.5 · SODOM AND GOMORRAH BY THE DEAD SEA · GEN 13:10–13; 18,16-19,29

When the herdsmen of Abram and Lot begin to quarrel over pasture, Abram proposes that they part. Lot chooses the well-watered plain of the Jordan, which reminds him of a garden, and pitches his tents near Sodom. The inhabitants of the city are described as cruel to strangers. Abraham pleads with God on their behalf, but there are too few righteous people. Lot flees with his daughters, and the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah are destroyed. In the morning Abraham looks down from the height and sees smoke rising like smoke from a furnace. The story has a moral dimension, not a tourist one.

The Jordan Valley is the lowest place on earth: the shore of the Dead Sea lies about 430 m below sea level. The climate here is hot and dry, and the water of the sea contains about ten times more salt than the ocean. Natural bitumen and sulfur occur in the area, which explains the biblical images of fire and tar. From Hebron to the shore of the lakes is about 40 km down the slopes, which explains how Abraham could watch the valley from a height. The exact location of the cities is uncertain; tradition places them at the south or east of the sea.

FACTS

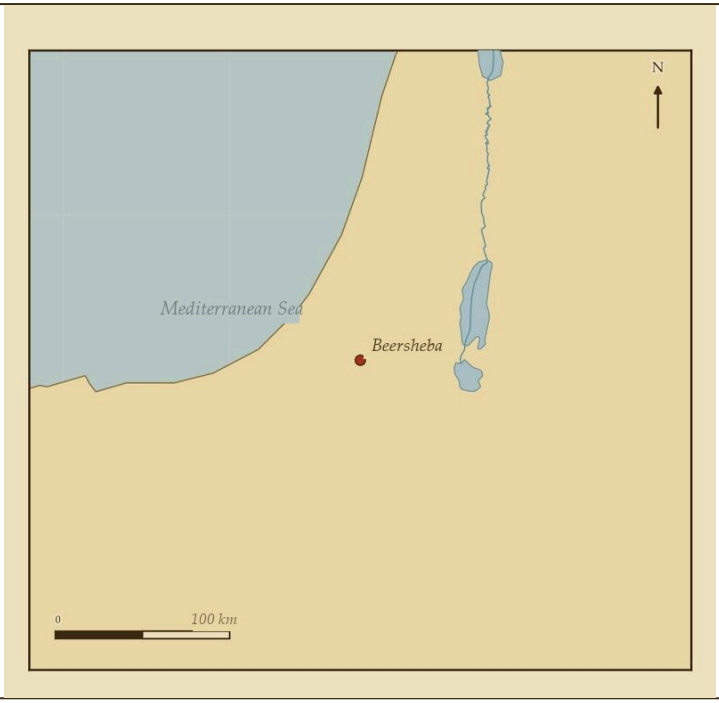
Level of the Dead Sea: about 430 m below sea level; length of the sea about 50 km.


N
Mediterranean Sea
Sodom & Gomorrah on the Dead Sea
0
100 km

06 Beersheba

GEN 21:22–34; 22; 26:23–33

The well of the oath on the edge of the desert, an important stop for Abraham and Isaac.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a wide, bright plain under a cloudless sky. In the middle is a stone well with a wooden windlass and troughs for the animals. A lone tamarisk grows nearby, and sheep graze all around. Low sand-colored hills trace the horizon, and beyond them lies dry steppe. Shepherds draw water in leather buckets and talk at the edge of the stone well curb.

2.6 · BEERSHEBA · GEN 21:22–34; 22; 26:23–33

The name Beersheba is associated with a well and an oath. Abimelech, the ruler from the region of Gerar, and his commander make a treaty with Abraham in which they recognize his right to the well he dug with his own hands. The patriarch plants a tamarisk tree and calls on the name of the Lord. From here he sets out for the mountain pointed out for the sacrifice of Isaac. Many years later Isaac reopens the wells that had been filled in and receives a promise of support. Here the well means life, property rights, and peace with neighbors.

Beersheba lies where the Negev meets the cultivated belt, at a spot where annual rainfall is only about 200 mm. Access to a well therefore decided whether flocks survived. This area was the southern edge of the permanently settled land, hence the later phrase "from Dan to Beersheba." The road to Hebron is about 45 km long and runs across dry hills. Shepherds traveled it seasonally, seeking grass after the winter rains. The site of Tel Sheva lies a few kilometers from the modern city.

FACTS

Beersheba to Hebron: about 45 km; rainfall about 200 mm per year.

07 Machpelah in Hebron

GEN 23; 25:7–10; 49:29–32

The only piece of land Abraham ever buys, to bury Sarah.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a field on a hillside, with a row of olive trees and a low stone wall. In a rock face opens the narrow entrance of a cave, covered by a flat boulder. Below runs a road leading to a town with flat stone roofs. In the setting sun everything takes on a golden hue. The atmosphere is quiet, full of solemnity and mourning.

Sarah dies in Kiriath Arba, that is, in Hebron. Abraham, as a foreigner, has no tomb of his own. He stands before the assembly of the city's inhabitants and asks to buy one. Ephron offers the field together with the cave, but the patriarch insists on settling the price, so that the matter is honestly sealed. He pays four hundred shekels of silver, and the transaction takes place publicly, at the city gate. This is how the family tomb comes about, in which Abraham, Isaac, Rebekah, Leah, and Jacob would later be laid.

Hebron lies about 30 km south of Jerusalem, at an elevation of about 900 m, in one of the oldest centers of settlement in Judea. The area is hilly, rocky, and full of natural limestone caves, which often served as tombs. Tradition locates Machpelah beneath a structure from the time of Herod, which to this day encloses a site revered by Jews, Christians, and Muslims. The Herodian wall is about 60 m long and clearly visible. The exact layout of the caves remains closed to full archaeological study.

FACTS

Price of the field about 400 shekels of silver; Hebron about 900 m above sea level.

08 Bethel – Jacob's Dream

GEN 28:10–22; 35:1–15

A fugitive sleeps on a stone and sees heaven open over the earth.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows an evening sky over a stony hill. A lone figure sleeps on the ground, head on a flat stone, seen from a great distance. Above, a bright streak of light parts the clouds, forming a fan of rays descending toward the earth. Boulders lie all around, and a few thorny shrubs grow. Far below, a gentle valley looms. The air holds the warm night after a hot day.

Jacob sets out from Beersheba for Haran, to escape his brother's vengeance and to find a wife among relatives. When dusk falls, he stops for the night, lays his head on a stone, and dreams of a ladder. Angels ascend and descend, and God renews the promise given to Abraham and Isaac. On waking, Jacob sets up the stone as a memorial, anoints it with oil, and names the place Bethel. Years later he returns here at God's command to fulfill his vow.

Bethel lies on the ridge of the hills of central Palestine, about 17 km north of Jerusalem, at an elevation of about 880 m above sea level. The stony terrain, sparse trees, and lack of convenient shelter meant that a lone traveler slept under the open sky. The ridge road linked Hebron with Shechem and was the main route of Palestine. Jacob covered about 100 km from Beersheba to Bethel, which corresponds to several days of travel. The identification with the village of Beitin is widely accepted.

FACTS

Bethel: about 880 m above sea level, about 17 km north of Jerusalem.


N
Bethel: Jacob's Dream
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

09 Jabbok and Penuel

GEN 32:23–33

A night struggle at the ford of the Jabbok changes Jacob's name to Israel.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

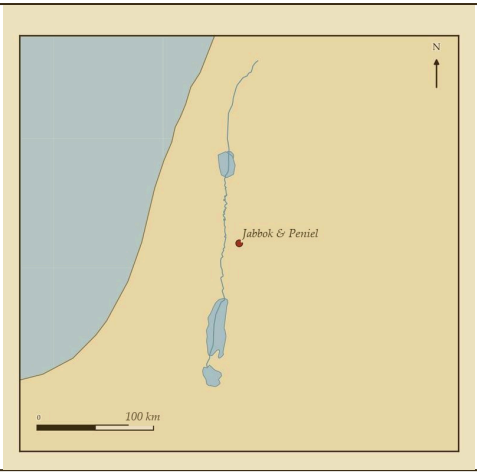
The artistic reconstruction shows a deep ravine at dusk. Shallow, swift water flows between stony banks, and on the far side a herd of animals and a few tents can be seen. In the foreground, in the gloom, two dark figures are locked in a struggle, visible from afar. The sky in the east brightens, heralding dawn. Oleander bushes cover the slopes, and the chill of night hangs in the air.

Returning after years from Haran, Jacob learns that Esau is coming to meet him with four hundred men. In the night he sends his wives, children, and possessions across the ford of the Jabbok, and stays alone on the other side. There he wrestles until dawn with a mysterious figure, who touches his hip and changes the patriarch's name to Israel. In the morning Jacob names the place Penuel, because he has seen God face to face, and he limps for the rest of his life. The next day he meets his brother in reconciliation.

The Jabbok, today the Zarqa River, is a tributary of the Jordan flowing from the hills of Gilead in the east. The river cuts into a deep, rocky ravine, and in the dry season it can be crossed in several places. Penuel stood near the ford, about 10 km east of the Jordan. From Haran to Penuel it is about 600 km in a straight line, so the journey with flocks took many weeks. The exact location is uncertain; Tulul edh-Dhahab on the lower course of the river is often suggested.

FACTS

The Jabbok is about 100 km long; Penuel lies about 10 km east of the Jordan.


N
Jabbok & Peniel
0
100 km

10 Dothan

GEN 37:12–36

Near cisterns and a caravan route, the brothers sell Joseph.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a green valley beneath gentle hills. Flocks of sheep graze on the slopes, and in the distance a group of shepherds stands under a tree. From the other side of the valley a caravan of camels approaches, loaded with sacks and jars. In the foreground is the stone opening of a cistern, partly hidden by bushes. The light is sharp, afternoon light, and the shadows are long.

Jacob sends Joseph from Hebron to check on how his brothers are doing. Joseph goes by way of Shechem and learns that the flocks have moved on to Dothan. The brothers see him from afar, dressed in his distinctive robe, and decide to be rid of him. They throw him into an empty cistern. When a caravan of Ishmaelite merchants passes by, they pull Joseph out and sell him for twenty pieces of silver. They bring their father the bloodstained robe, and he sinks into mourning.

Dothan lies in a valley north of Shechem, about 25 km in a straight line. Through it passed the road linking the Jezreel Valley with the coast and on to Egypt, so caravans with balm and resin traveled this way regularly. The valley has fertile pastures ringed by hills, and cisterns were hewn in the rock to store water. From Hebron to Dothan is about 100 km, and to Egypt over 400 km. Tell Dothan has been explored archaeologically and shows Bronze Age settlement.

FACTS

Dothan–Hebron: about 100 km; Joseph's sale price about 20 pieces of silver.



11 Egypt and Memphis

GEN 39–41

A slave from Canaan becomes the steward of the granaries of the land on the Nile.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

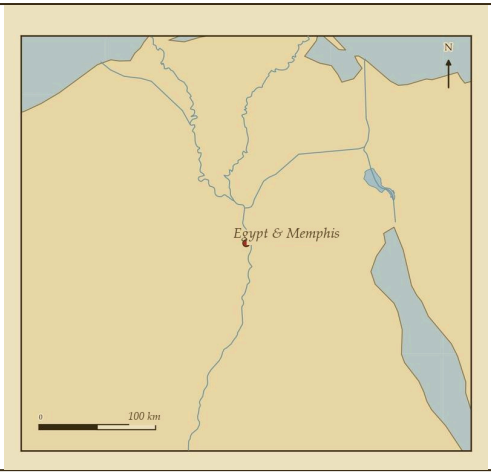
The artistic reconstruction shows the broad Nile, with sailing barges gliding along it, and green fields on both banks. Beyond them stretch the desert and low pyramids in the hazy distance. Along the quay stand long granaries of mud brick, and workers carry baskets of grain. On a palace terrace a small figure stands with its back turned, watching the work. The air is warm and bright, smelling of water and straw.

In Egypt, Joseph works in the house of Potiphar, a courtier of Pharaoh. He is falsely accused and lands in prison, where he interprets the dreams of two officials. When Pharaoh has troubling dreams about cows and ears of grain, Joseph is remembered. The young Hebrew explains that after seven plentiful years seven years of famine will come. Pharaoh entrusts him with overseeing the storing of grain, gives him an Egyptian name, and raises him to high office. The text stresses that Joseph's rise comes from wisdom and God's good care.

Egypt depended on the yearly flooding of the Nile, which deposited fertile silt on the fields. When the flood was too low or too high, famine and disaster threatened. Memphis, at the apex of the delta, was an important center of administration and trade. From it to the Mediterranean coast is about 200 km. Granaries stored grain in clay-and-brick silos, and officials recorded the supplies. The biblical text does not give the name of the pharaoh, so the exact dating of the events remains a subject of research.

FACTS

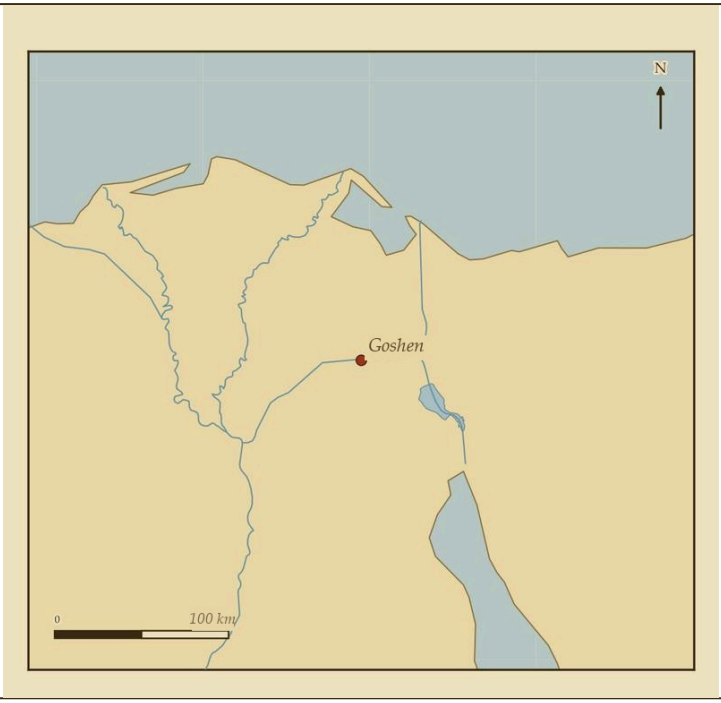
Memphis–Mediterranean Sea: about 200 km; the Nile flood lasted several months.


N
Egypt & Memphis
0
100 km

12 Goshen

GEN 45:9–11; 46:28–34; 47:1–12

A region in the eastern Nile delta, where Jacob's family settles.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a flat, green plain crisscrossed by canals. Flocks of sheep and cattle graze beside rows of palms, and in the background enclosures of reed and clay can be seen. The shepherds wear simple, light robes. The air is humid and the sky wide. On the horizon the low dunes of the desert take shape, separated from the region by a sharp band of green.

Years later, Joseph reveals himself to his brothers and asks them to bring their father. Jacob sets out from Beersheba with his whole family, and on the way receives God's assurance of care. Joseph goes out to meet him and presents him to Pharaoh. The ruler assigns the settlers the land of Goshen as the best region for their flocks. This is how a community begins that will grow from seventy persons into a nation. Genesis ends with the death of Joseph and the promise that God will bring his descendants back to Canaan.

Goshen is usually located in the eastern part of the Nile delta, in the Wadi Tumilat, about 100 km from Memphis toward the Sinai Peninsula. It was a strip of well-watered meadows, ideal for sheep and cattle, and at the same time close to the border, so it was easy to move flocks from Canaan. The road from Beersheba across Sinai is about 250 km, or a dozen or so days of travel. The exact boundaries of the region are uncertain, and the identification rests on tradition and analysis of routes.

FACTS

Goshen lies about 100 km from Memphis; the road from Beersheba is about 250 km.

Questions for Reflection

1. Why could Abraham trust the promise without knowing the destination of his journey, and what in your life requires a similar trust in an unknown road?

2. How do the wells, trees, and caves in the stories of the patriarchs point to the value of hospitality, peace with neighbors, and remembering our ancestors?

3. What changes in the story of Joseph when we recognize that the road from Dothan to Egypt was a trade route, not a mysterious expedition into the unknown?